

there is an almost negligible cost difference. However, when advanced features such as voicemail, Automatic Call Distributor (ACD), Interactive Voice Response System (IVRS) and Computer Telephony Integration (CTI) are added, the cost with Asterisk is significantly lower than traditional PBXs. You cannot compare Asterisk PBXs with low-end analogue PBXs as Asterisk offers many other features not available in low-end analogue systems. In comparison with proprietary software, which offer such features, using Asterisk costs a lot less.

Enables complete control over the telephony system

Asterisk provides independence and allows users to do what they want to with their PBX system. A few proprietary manufacturers do not even give the customer the system's password or the configuration documentation. With Asterisk, the user achieves total freedom and, as a bonus, access to a standard interface.

Allows customisation of source code

Asterisk can be extended using script languages like PHP and Perl with AMI and AGI interfaces. And since it is open source, its source code can be modified by the user. The source code is mostly in the ANSI C programming language.

Flexible and powerful dial plans

Another Asterisk breakthrough is its powerful dial plan. In traditional PBXs, even simple features like Least Cost Routing (LCR) are either not feasible or are offered as additional options. With Asterisk, choosing the best route is easy and clean.

Feature rich

The cost of features in some platforms exceeds the cost of the platform. With Asterisk's extensive features available at a cheaper price, you can do almost everything allowed on a phone. Listed below are some relevant features.

- Call queuing
 - Call recording
 - Call transfer
 - Call waiting
 - Voicemail
 - Voicemail to email
 - Voicemail groups
 - Web voicemail interface
 - Caller ID
 - Supervised transfer
 - SMS messaging
 - Call parking
 - Remote call pickup
 - Conference bridging
 - Database store/retrieve
 - Database integration
- Source: asterisk.org

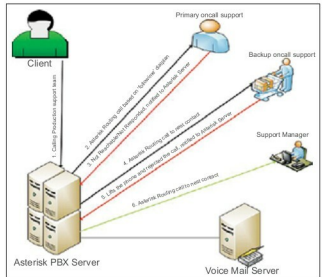


Figure 1: Asterisk – the 'FollowMe' call flow

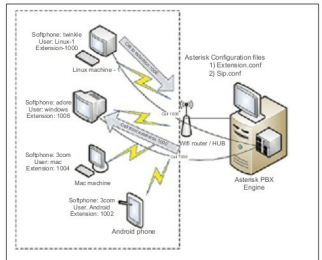


Figure 2: Softphone to softphone communication

Key features

Asterisk comes bundled with a host of exciting features. Here are some details of a few key features.

Follow me

This feature will ensure the calls are addressed either by the individual or the respective team members. For example, in a scenario in which a client is trying to reach production support on a critical issue:

1. The client dials the primary on-call person.
2. Asterisk routes the call to this person based on the 'FollowMe' dial plan.
3. Primary on-call person is not reachable so a 'Not Responded' notification is sent out.
4. Asterisk routes the call to the backup on-call support person.
5. The backup on-call person picks up and hears the